

The .vimrc file

The EX commands (those that you key in after typing : in the Vi editor), which you want to execute whenever you start the Vi editor, can be saved in the .vimrc file in your home directory. If this file is not already there, you can create it. The .vimrc file can be modified like any other text file. Examples of some settings are given in Table 1.

Table 1

Command	Short form	Action
set number	se nu	Displays line numbers
set nonumber	Se nonu	Removes line numbers
set autoindent	se ai	Automatic indentation in insert mode
Set noautoindent	Se noai	Removes the automatic indentation feature in insert mode
se tabstop=3	se ts=3	Sets the number of spaces by which the tab indents during editing
syntax on		Turns on highlighting of syntax
syntax off		Turns off highlighting of syntax
set shiftwidth=4	set sw=4	The size of the indent, measured in spaces

Inserting the contents of an existing file

Often, we need to insert the contents of an existing file into the current file. The Vi editor provides an easy way to do this. Take the cursor to the position at which you want the insertion and issue the following command:

```
:r filename
```

This inserts the contents of the file from the current cursor position onwards.

Adding a number before r inserts the text file below the line with the particular line number:

```
:40r filename
```

Running an external command within Vi

You can execute any command within the Vi editor by typing the following command within the command mode of Vi:

```
!:commandname
```

Insert the output of a Linux command

You can insert the output of a command by giving the following command:

```
!r! :commandname
```

The command is executed and the output is inserted from the position where the cursor is located.

Opening Vi directly at a particular line

You can open the Vim editor with the cursor placed directly at the line you want, by giving the following command:

```
$vim filename +n
```

The number 'n' in the command is the line number.

Opening Vi at the end of the file

Adding the + sign and a space before the file name, opens the file and places the cursor at the last line. This is useful if you have to work on large files.

```
$vim + filename
```

Writing the buffer to a new file

:w can be used to save the complete buffer, that is, the file being edited currently, under a new file name. This can be used when you have made a lot of changes in the file, but then realise that you do not want to overwrite the original file. To save the contents of the buffer, use the following command:

```
:w newname
```

You can now quit the original file by typing :q.

Indenting the source code

In case you have typed dozens of lines of code without bothering about indentation, the quickest way to indent the code is to do the following:

Press the Esc key to go to command mode and then type the following:

```
gg=G
```

...where gg indicates the beginning of the file, = is for indenting and G indicates the end of the file.

Repeating the last change

We can use the . (period) key to repeat the last change. This helps to reduce the typing required when carrying out repetitive tasks.

Undoing and redoing

Type u to undo the last change.

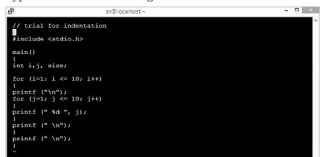


Figure 1: A code snippet without indent